

IP Location Disclosure on Chinese Social Media and Support for State Digital Control

Wanzi Wang

Causal Research Proposal

March 9, 2026

The full written version of the research proposal is released upon request.

Research Question and Policy Background

Research Question

Does making users' IP-based location visible increase targeting and hostility toward “outsiders” online?

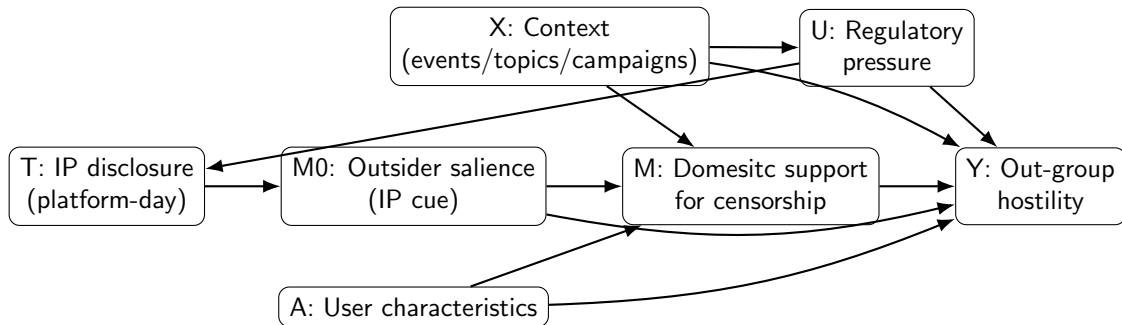
Policy background

- ▶ Platforms introduced **mandatory Internet Protocol (IP) location** (province/country) in 2022 on *Weibo*, justified as improving transparency and reducing misinformation.
- ▶ **Staggered rollout across platforms** (and sometimes across product surfaces), enabling quasi-experimental comparison.
- ▶ **Counterfactual**: hostility trend (posts, comments, tags, etc.) on platforms that have not yet adopted the disclosure policy (in the same calendar days).

Empirical focus (thread-day $\times$ platform)

- ▶ **Main outcome: Out-group hostility** (rate of hostile targeting of perceived outsiders; e.g., foreigners, Chinese people, “foreign forces”).
- ▶ **Mediator: Outsider salience and support for censorship** (revealed support for state authority and media censorship).

Causal Model (DAG)



Reading: Mandatory IP location disclosure (T), shaped by context (X) and regulatory pressure (U), raises outsider salience (M0), which increases out-group hostility (Y) both directly and indirectly through Support for censorship (M), with user characteristics (A) moderating overall levels.

Front-door vs Back-door Paths (and How to Close Them)

All front-door paths from T to Y :

- ▶ $T \rightarrow M_0 \rightarrow Y$
- ▶ $T \rightarrow M_0 \rightarrow M \rightarrow Y$

All back-door paths from T to Y :

- ▶ $T \leftarrow U \rightarrow Y$ condition on U
- ▶ $T \leftarrow U \rightarrow M \rightarrow Y$ condition on U
- ▶ $T \leftarrow U \leftarrow X \rightarrow Y$ condition on U
- ▶ $T \leftarrow U \leftarrow X \rightarrow M \rightarrow Y$ condition on X

What NOT to control:

- ▶ M_0 or M (mediators).
- ▶ Post-treatment variables (e.g., engagement/visibility).

References I

-  Ho, W.-C. (2022). The Surge of Nationalist Sentiment among Chinese Youth during the COVID-19 Pandemic. *China: An International Journal*, 20(4), 1–22.
-  Liu, Y., Wu, Y., Li, C., Song, C., & Hsu, W. (2024). Does displaying one's IP location influence users' privacy behavior on social media? Evidence from China's Weibo. *Telecommunications Policy*, 48(5), 102759. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.telpol.2024.102759>
-  Lu, Y., Xie, Z., Chiu, D. K. W., & Kafeza, E. (2025). Digital Exposure and Emotional Response: Public Discourse on Mandatory IP Location Disclosure in Chinese Social Media. *Systems*, 13(11), 975. <https://doi.org/10.3390/systems13110975>
-  Neo, R., & Xiang, C. (2022). State rhetoric, nationalism and public opinion in China. *International Affairs*, 98(4), 1327–1346. <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiaa105>
-  Wu, Z. (2026). Outsiders in the Media: How a Sense of “Foreignness” Shapes Support for Censorship in China. *Political Communication*, 43(1), 65–88. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10584609.2025.2529926>

References II

-  Yang, L. (2023). Sowing Division: The Unintended Consequences of Geographic Tagging on Social Media. *SSRN Electronic Journal*. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.4560720>
-  Yang, L. Y., & Xu, Y. (2025). User Location Disclosure Fails to Deter Overseas Criticism but Amplifies Regional Divisions on Chinese Social Media. *SSRN Electronic Journal*. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.4560720>
-  Yu, C., & Margolin, D. (2024). Topic territoriality and the cost of civility: Examining the impact of IP address disclosure on Weibo. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, 29(6), zmae018. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jcmc/zmae018>
-  Zhang, Y., & Xu, D. (2025). The Effects of IP Address Revelation on Location-Based Name-Calling and User Engagement: Evidence From a Chinese Online Platform. *Journal of the Association for Information Systems*, 26(5), 1268–1293. <https://doi.org/10.17705/1jais.00947>